

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 67

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1964

Coverage Date: Ca. 1958-1964

Place Coverage: G/Wi San, Botswana

Section Title(S): (5) The Effects Of The System.

The most powerful force acting towards the unity of the band is friendship and good fellowship. The philosophy of G/wi social life is that people should get on well together, but the force of friendship must have some social framework within which it can develop, and needs some catalyst before it can act. These are supplied, at least in part, by the kinship system which gives dimension to the group in which an individual finds himself, by prescribing those to whom he should cleave and those who are more distant and by ordaining his rôles in interacting with them.

571
[Social Relationships
 And Groups](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

621
[Community Structure](#)

The expectation implicit in the relationship that all kin in that category shall freely allow use of their possessions and share their food ensures an even distribution of goods and provisions and acts as a form of mutual assistance or insurance, and prevents envy and jealousy. The uninhibited and unresented comment to which the relationship gives licence, acts as a check on both anti-social behaviour and the resentment it would cause before the effects of either can become too serious and the free-and-easy behaviour expected of joking partners provides an effective and innocuous outlet for emotions which, if bottled up, would lead to the development of tensions and conflicts.

182
[Functional/Adaptational
 Interpretations](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

It has been mentioned that joking partners of opposite sexes, if of appropriate ages, are considered to be potentially marriageable. The intimate relationships permitted between them give them a good opportunity [68](#) to get to know each other, and for others to judge their suitability to each other, before marrying.

582
[Regulation Of Marriage](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

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